

Jordan, Saudi Arabia and Israel have already deployed Open edX and launched their educational courses online. In India, premier institutions like IIT, Bombay, have used Open edX and designed a site particularly for a teacher training programme. Many government agencies in India and across the globe are also thinking of deploying Open edX.

“We would love to see the government deploy Open edX and launch a national platform to spread the next generation of education in India.”

We think that by making edX open source, we can maximise the good that we are doing in the world instead of hiding the software and keeping it just for ourselves. If we were a for-profit company, then not giving away the software would be a good thing to do. But this is the best way for a non-profit organisation to reach a massive audience—by offering an open source solution.

Q What are all the open source technologies behind Open edX?

Open edX is based on some foundational cloud systems such as Apache, Python and Django, among others. Also, there are tools for e-commerce and for assessments. We are also offering APIs to let third-party developers integrate our sources into their projects. There is a huge business ecosystem around edX, but anything that we develop, we make it open source.

The original technology behind edX was based on Python and Django. We also used Nginx for the Web software and deployed Amazon Web Server. Similarly, the present platform has open source technologies like JavaScript and HTML5 on the design front and Ruby on Rails for the discussion forum.

All in all, we can say edX is powered by Open edX and that is available for free to the world.

Q How easy is it to develop a solution like edX?

We started edX in 2012. It is very challenging to build a non-profit organisation and hard to raise money if you are offering anything free to the public. Building a non-profit model is not easy because there is no standard model for investment. But we were grateful to MIT and Harvard. We could not launch as a non-profit without support from both these institutions.

Today, we have the support of more than one hundred institutional partners, including some of the top universities in the world.

If you build software that is only used by you, then you can focus just on that software. But as we made it open source at edX, we have a team that is focused on Open edX and is maintaining the Open edX community to generate traction from various engineering resources. This certainly complements our own efforts at edX, because sometimes people want some support and help for particular features that are also useful for edX.

Q Do you think MOOC providers like edX will transform the traditional classroom culture in the coming future?

We are transforming the classroom culture in many ways. I call this process of transformation of traditional classrooms and universities ‘unbundling’. If you look at a traditional university today, it is one bundle. You need to start in the first year, go through various sessions and then finish after some time, say three or four years.

We are partnering with various worldwide institutions and creating more hybrid solutions that are unbundled. So we are trying to unbundle the three Cs—the clock (or the time), curriculum and credentials.

Through MicroMasters, we are unbundling the clock and offering students education in a shorter span of time than any traditional university. We are also unbundling the credentials using solutions like MicroMasters, and enabling students to complete a masters programme by spending half the time and effort as well as at two or three per cent of the total normal cost. Besides, we are unbundling the curriculum by offering online content to students.

“We’ve launched some of the hottest job-related courses to reduce unemployment.”

Most universities are now moving in the direction of blended education, which combines both online and in-person teaching. Presently, nine out of ten undergraduate students are using edX as part of their campus curriculum at MIT. In the next 20 to 30 years, all education is likely to become blended.

Q What are your views on the education system in India? Also, how can we improve the present system using advancements like edX?

The education system is not perfect anywhere in the world. There are many challenges in the education system worldwide; India has its own challenges. Indian professors and teachers are quite dedicated. Likewise, institutions like the IITs and IIMs are in line with some leading universities overseas.

However, there are challenges in the style of